



Home Connect

Connecting Children, Strengthening Families, Building Futures

CHILD PROTECTION AND SAFEGUARDING HANDBOOK

Section 1: Introduction

1.1 Purpose of the Handbook

This handbook outlines Home Connect's commitment to child protection and safeguarding. It serves as a practical guide for staff, guardians, volunteers, and partners to ensure the safety, dignity, and well-being of every child under our care.

1.2 Organizational Commitment

Home Connect is a Zimbabwean-based social enterprise dedicated to supporting children of local and diaspora parents. We recognize the vulnerabilities caused by physical separation and we are committed to providing protective, empowering, and culturally responsive services.

Section 2: Legal Framework

2.1 National Laws

- ❖ Constitution of Zimbabwe (2013) – Section 81: Rights of children
- ❖ Children's Act Chapter 5:06 (Amended 2023) – Child welfare and protection
- ❖ Domestic Violence Act [Chapter 5:16] – Protection from domestic abuse
- ❖ Criminal Law (Codification and Reform) Act [Chapter 9:23] – Sexual offences and exploitation

2.2 International Conventions

- ❖ UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC)
- ❖ African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child

Section 3: Scope and Applicability

- All Home Connect employees and contractors
- Approved guardians and caregivers
- Volunteers and interns Partner institutions (schools, NGOs, churches)

10 Aberdeen Road, Avondale, Harare, Zimbabwe OR 6665 Santa Cristina, Dallas, TX, USA

Email: info@homeconnect.co.zw

Phone: +263 78 018 5878 / +1 (903) 990-9760



Section 4: Key Definitions

Term	Definition
Child	Any person under 18 years of age
Abuse	Physical, emotional, sexual harm or neglect
Neglect	Failure to provide adequate care or supervision
Safeguarding	Preventing harm and promoting child welfare
Child in Need of Care	As defined in Children's Act Chapter(5:06): orphaned, abandoned, abused, neglected, or vulnerable

Section 5: Guiding Principles

- Best Interests of the Child: All actions prioritize the child's safety and development.
- Zero Tolerance: No abuse, neglect, or exploitation is tolerated.
- Confidentiality: Child information is protected and shared only when necessary.
- Participation: Children are encouraged to express their views.
- Cultural Sensitivity: Services respect Zimbabwean and diaspora cultures.

Section 6: Prevention Measures

- ✓ Vetting Procedures – Staff: Background checks, police clearance, reference verification
- ✓ Vetting Procedures – Guardians: Home visits, identity checks, suitability assessments
- ✓ Mandatory Training – Child rights, recognizing abuse, reporting, first aid, nutrition
- ✓ Code of Conduct – Maintain professional boundaries and respect children

Section 7: Reporting and Response Protocols

- Mandatory Reporting – Report to Department of Social Development (Social Welfare) and ZRP Victim Friendly Unit
- Internal Procedure – Document, report to Child Protection Officer, notify authorities within 24 hours, provide emergency support
- Emergency Response – 24/7 helpline, on-site support, coordination with police/hospitals

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Section 8: Monitoring and Oversight

- Welfare Check-ins – Regular home and school visits
- Parent Reporting – Updates via email, WhatsApp or phone calls
- Annual Audits – Internal and external evaluations

Section 9: Child Participation

- ✓ Children are educated on their rights and responsibilities.
- ✓ Feedback mechanisms - child-friendly interviews, peer support groups

Section 10: Partnerships

- ❖ Schools – academic monitoring
- ❖ NGOs – psychosocial support
- ❖ Churches – community engagement
- ❖ Government departments – statutory protection

Section 11: Digital Safety

- ❖ Secure data systems for child records
- ❖ Consent required for media sharing
- ❖ No unauthorized social media posts

Section 12: Policy Review

- Reviewed annually or upon legal changes
- Stakeholder input incorporated
- Updated versions shared with all stakeholders